

CAREER PATHS

Although competition for entry-level jobs is high, police work offers good prospects for career progression. After successfully completing an initial training period, officers can then specialize in a range of different roles. Promotion through senior roles is based on performance. Officers are also encouraged—and, in some states, required—to take ongoing training throughout their career.

GRADUATE You need a good general education to apply for entry positions. The exact requirements vary between regional police forces, but a bachelor's degree along with experience of community work, volunteering alongside police officers in your local area, or working as a police community support officer will improve your prospects.

POLICE OFFICER After an initial training period, which varies by state and involves training in investigative methods, policing skills, and legislation, officers progress by choosing a specialization.

RIVER POLICE Performs river or coastal patrols on specialty police vessels, investigating illegal activity and arresting criminals. River police train in areas including advanced boat handling or diving.

DETECTIVE Investigates serious crimes, including murder, assault, theft, sexual offenses, and fraud. A detective's duties include gathering information, collecting evidence, and interviewing suspects.

**TRAFFIC OFFICER/
PATROLMAN** Specializes in road safety, dealing with traffic offenses, responding to accidents, and checking vehicles to ensure they are insured and taxed.

SPECIALTY OFFICER Prevents crime or apprehends criminals using specialized training or techniques. Officers can work in areas such as child protection, vice, fraud, or narcotics (drugs), or undergo training in the use of firearms and special tactics, such as anti-terrorism.

SKILLS GUIDE



The ability to communicate clearly and confidently in potentially dangerous situations.



Good team-working skills for collaborating on cases with colleagues and specialty officers.



The capacity to behave with tact, diplomacy, and respect when dealing with the public.



Solid problem-solving skills to respond quickly, effectively, and appropriately to crisis situations.



Physical strength to pursue and apprehend criminals, and mental stamina to stay calm at all times.

